

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Carbon monoxide

HOME BUILDING / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

If a CO alarm sounds or carbon monoxide exposure is suspected, get everyone into fresh air immediately and call emergency services. Do not stay inside to find the source. Headache, dizziness, nausea or confusion can be warning signs.

Do now.

**Leave the building**

01

Move people and pets into fresh air, without delaying to ventilate or troubleshoot.

**Call from outside**

02

Report the alarm, symptoms and possible fuel-burning source to emergency services.

**Get medical help**

03

Tell responders about suspected exposure even if symptoms improve outdoors.

**Wait for clearance**

04

Do not reenter until responders say it is safe.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Leave the building even if responders cannot be reached. Gather outside away from exhaust, keep everyone out and seek reachable medical care for symptoms. Do not send someone back inside to ventilate or switch equipment off.

Watch for.

CO is invisible and odorless. A silent smoke alarm is not proof that air is safe.

People & practical needs.

Children, sleeping people and people with limited mobility may not recognize symptoms or reach fresh air independently. Assign evacuation help in advance and keep functioning CO alarms near sleeping areas. Do not make a symptomatic person drive.

Keep essentials within reach.

Prioritize supplies named in this guide that are usable by the person who needs them. Keep the checklist and relevant contact details accessible. Check carrying capacity, storage and equipment instructions in advance; collecting equipment must not delay the immediate protective action.

Next decisions.

Install CO alarms and service heating equipment. Keep generators and grills outdoors, far from openings.

Questions in the field.

Can I turn off the appliance first?

Move everyone to fresh air before investigating. A fuel-burning appliance may continue exposing people while it is being inspected. Call from outside and do not reenter until the hazard has been assessed by appropriate qualified personnel.

Can the household sleep elsewhere inside?

Changing rooms is not a reliable answer to a suspected CO exposure. Get outside to fresh air and seek medical evaluation for symptoms. Keep people together so confusion, faintness or worsening breathing is noticed.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

Carbon monoxide · official guidance

<https://www.cdc.gov/carbon-monoxide/about/index.html>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/carbon-monoxide/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.